The XXXIII Corps was then joined by IV Corps in attacking the Japanese along the Dimapur-Imphal Road on June 22, 1944. When British and Indian troops took milestone 109 the siege of Imphal was lifted. The Japanese 33rd Division was reinforced by battalions from the 53rd and 54th Divisions. The Japanese continued to press their attack on Indian troops despite previous setbacks. The Japanese came close to penetrating the Indian lines at Bishenpur, but suffered high casualties, which ended the offensive on July 3, 1944. The defeats at Imphal and Kohima are the largest defeats in Japanese military history. The Japanese suffered over 55,000 wounded with 13,500 killed.

THE BEGINNING OF THE END—THE HUKAWNG CAMPAIGN

The Allies main priority in the Burma theatre was to reopen the supply route to China. The Hukawng campaign had multiple objectives: to cut the Allied supply route connecting India and China, to provide flank protection for the Imphal operation, and to capture a large number or Allied troops. U.S. trained and equipped Chinese divisions and smaller American units advanced into Hukawng at the end of the monsoon season in November 1943, ostensibly to reopen the Burma Road. At the time of the Allied advance Japanese units in Upper Burma had assumed a defensive posture to support offensives against India.

The battle for Hukawng began in early 1944 when the Japanese 18th Division advanced westward toward Ledo across the Hukawng valley. The operation was designed to forestall the Allied offensive in the west of Kamaing and to engage as many Chinese and American forces as possible. In February 1944, the 1st and 6th armies under the command of Lieutenant General Joseph W. Stilwell as well as “Merrill's Marauders,” part of the 6th Airborne Division gradually pushed the Japanese 18th Division to retreat to Myitkyina. Strategically, Myitkyina was important in the Burma theatre. If the Allies could take Myitkyina, they could isolate Japanese forces between Hukawng and Yunnan fronts, as well as open the way for the Allies to threaten Mandalay.

THE BATTLE FOR MYITKYINA